

Element A: Presentation and Justification of the Problem

At our independent boarding school we have an ongoing paper waste problem. Paper is being wasted because teachers and students sometimes print on only one side of the paper or make mistakes when using the printer or photocopier. This is a large-scale issue, over 200,000 pages have already been printed or photocopied this school year alone, and we still have three months until the end of the school year (Mr. B, personal communication, March 31, 2026). We need to find a solution to reuse the printed and photocopied paper to prevent it from being wasted and going into a landfill.

Solving this problem would reduce paper waste, which will help teachers, students, and staff, by giving them more paper that is usable without buying more new paper. However, solving this solution can lead to confusion on which paper is usable, and how to use it. Also, some people may not feel the need to reuse paper. Many other schools and organizations face similar issues when it comes to paper waste. Most of them throw away partially used paper which wastes material and money (Business Waste 2024). This problem can also relate to environmental concerns like conserving trees.

Our primary stakeholders are our school's teachers, staff, and students. People who also might be interested in a solution include loggers, sustainability groups, and waste management services. Due to excessive paper waste, there is a need to reuse paper that has already been printed or written on. The solution will decrease paper waste, cut costs, lessen how many trees are being cut down, and how much paper is being thrown away.

Reducing paper waste saves trees, reduces toxins being released into the

environment, paper waste accounts for almost 12% of landfill waste (Tads 2023). A typical school with 300 students prints around 10,000 pieces of paper a week. It is estimated that around two thirds of paper waste in schools could be avoided (Business Waste 2024).

Solving this problem now is important because paper waste continues to stockpile, which increases cost and unnecessary deforestation. Finding a solution to reuse misprinted paper would save resources, cut costs, and would be more sustainable.

References

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